western and eastern coasts, these found large markets for their wares in the cities of Gangetic India. The *Arthashastra* describes the Dakshinapatha as preferable to other routes, singling out conch-shells, diamonds, rubies, pearls, and gold as plentiful along this route.[9] Along with this trade, mendicants moved from North India to the Deccan and back, a movement reflected in the story of the Brahman sage Bavari of Sravasti, who went along the southern route and settled down on the banks of the Godavari. On learning that the prince of the Sakyas, the Buddha, had become a mendicant, he sent sixteen of his disciples to Rajagriha, the old capital of Magadha, to meet the great sage.[10]

Regions along this route are also sometimes depicted as being different from those in the North. Avanti, for instance, is shown in the literature as different in its practices and customs from places in the Gangetic plains. It is described as the land where people attach great importance to bathing, and where 'sheep-skins, goat-skins, and deer-skins were used as coverlets.'[11] Ashoka will have noted such differences as he travelled towards Ujjayini.

Considering that Pataliputra and Ujjayini were separated by nearly a thousand kilometres, a splendid retinue of elephants and chariots is not likely to have accompanied the armed contingent and provision-laden carts required for the expedition too far. The ceremonials were probably only heraldry at the beginning and conclusion of expeditions, in the manner of 'triumphs' allowed by Romans to their great generals, such as Pompey and Julius Caesar, a couple of centuries later. Many more centuries later, in the time of the Mughal emperors, on the best-maintained royal road from Agra to Lahore, the average daily distance covered by caravans was a little over 30 km. Thus, in Mauryan times, on a far more difficult traverse from the Gangetic heartland into Central India, 30 km would have been a steep distance to aim for as the daily average. If we allow 25 km per day, Ashoka's journey to the viceregal region will have taken him 40 days. The